1935. Arthur Tansley coins the term “ecosystem” to describe an interdependent community of biological and non-biological components.

1939. In their book Bioecology, Frederic Clements and Victor Shelford popularise the idea of the biome.

1947. Lesley Holdridge’s biogeographic classification maps 38 life zones where vegetation is determined by rain and heat.

1953. Eugene and Howard Odum describe the living planet as a global collection of interlocking systems.

1970. The first Earth Day is celebrated, and the idea that humans should view Earth holistically grows in popularity.

1974. James Lovelock’s Gaia hypothesis presents Earth as a single, self-regulating system.

2000s. Scientists suggest that Earth could be in the midst of a sixth mass extinction event, due to the impact of human activity.